

**Partisan Animosity, Outgroup Dehumanization, and Political Violence: A Three-Study
Mediation Analysis**

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Abstract

This paper tests whether outgroup dehumanization mediates the relationship between *partisan animosity* — operationalized as outparty feeling thermometer coldness — and support for political violence. Partisan animosity is conceptually distinguished from the broader construct of affective polarization (the in-minus-out-party thermometer spread) and from negative partisanship (the motivational orientation of organizing partisan identity around outparty opposition). These three constructs are related but non-identical; this paper uses partisan animosity as its focal independent variable while situating it within the upstream causal structure that the affective polarization and negative partisanship literatures describe. Two individual-level hypotheses are tested: H1, that dehumanization significantly mediates the animosity-to-violence pathway; and H2, that this mediated pathway is significantly stronger among Republicans than Democrats. A third study establishes macro-level external validity. Study 1 presents a corrected random-effects meta-analysis (DerSimonian & Laird, 1986) synthesizing $k = 37$ effect sizes, yielding approximate pooled estimates of $r = .454$, $r = .339$, and $r = .130$ for the animosity/polarization→dehumanization, dehumanization→violence, and animosity→violence pathways. Study 2 conducts bootstrapped mediation on the Landry, Druckman, and Willer (2024) dataset ($N = 2,003$), demonstrating a significant indirect effect of partisan animosity on support for political violence through dehumanization ($\beta = +.085$, 95% CI [.057, .111], Sobel $z = 6.48$, $p < .001$). The pattern is one of suppressor mediation: animosity alone carries no positive violence signal; dehumanization is the entire violence-relevant pathway. Corrected moderated mediation finds that this pathway is significantly stronger among Republicans ($\beta = .120$) than Democrats ($\beta = .056$), $\Delta\beta = +.064$, CI [.013, .118]. Study 3 replicates Piazza (2023) using V-DEM v16 across 118 democracies (1950–

2025), confirming that political polarization robustly predicts subsequent political violence ($\beta \approx .302-.340$, OLS specifications). All three studies converge to indicate partisan animosity generates support for political violence through outgroup dehumanization, while the results of Study 2 are consistent with H2.

Keywords: partisan animosity, affective polarization, negative partisanship, outgroup dehumanization, political violence, mediation, partisan asymmetry, democracy

Introduction

On January 6, 2021, a mob stormed the United States Capitol to prevent the certification of a presidential election. In June 2017, a gunman opened fire on Republican members of Congress at a charity baseball practice, having described the opposing party's leader as "inhuman" on social media. In October 2018, a man who had described Democratic officials as "liberal slime" and "scum degenerates" mailed pipe bombs to over a dozen political figures. These are not isolated incidents. They are the visible surface of a pattern. The United States is experiencing a period of partisan political violence whose psychological roots political science is only beginning to excavate.

The scholarly literature has documented the emotional preconditions of this violence with considerable precision. Partisans now hold intensely negative feelings toward members of the opposing party *as a group* — independent of whether they disagree on any specific policy. This phenomenon, termed *affective polarization* by Iyengar et al. (2012), describes the widening emotional gap between how citizens feel about their own party and how they feel about the other. Abramowitz and Webster (2016, 2018) identified a more specific structural form of this development, *negative partisanship*, in which partisan identity is organized primarily around *opposition to the outparty* rather than positive attachment to one's own. Webster's (2020) *American Rage* demonstrated empirically that the anger underlying this orientation erodes democratic norms and is strategically cultivated by political elites because it drives voter loyalty. But affective polarization and negative partisanship are distinct from the focal construct of the present study. What this paper measures and tests as its independent variable is *partisan animosity*, the emotional intensity of hostility directed toward specific members of the opposing party, operationalized as outparty feeling thermometer coldness on a 0–100 scale. Partisan animosity is one component of

affective polarization (the outparty pole of the in-minus-out spread) and a downstream product of negative partisanship; it is not synonymous with either.

What remains theoretically and empirically underdeveloped is the mechanism through which partisan animosity — intense hostility toward outpartisans — converts to willingness to endorse violence against them. The literature proposes outgroup dehumanization as this mechanism. When partisans come to perceive members of the opposing party as less than fully human — as primitive, savage, animal-like — the moral constraints that normally prohibit sanctioning violence against human beings are suspended (Bandura, 1999; Kelman, 1973; Kteily et al., 2015). Yet despite this theoretical clarity, no prior published study has formally tested whether dehumanization statistically mediates the specific relationship between *partisan animosity* — measured as outparty feeling thermometer coldness — and support for partisan violence using bootstrapped indirect effects in a partisan U.S. context. This paper fills that gap.

Two core hypotheses are tested. H1: outgroup dehumanization significantly mediates the relationship between partisan animosity and support for political violence, such that the indirect effect through dehumanization is significant under bootstrapped inference. H2: this mediated pathway is significantly stronger among Republicans than Democrats. Three convergent studies address these hypotheses: Study 1 (random-effects meta-analysis, $k = 37$ effect sizes); Study 2 (bootstrapped mediation on the Landry et al., 2024 dataset, $N = 2,003$); and Study 3 (V-DEM v16 cross-national panel, 118 democracies, 1950–2025). The empirical architecture is designed so that each study substantiates a different level of the causal claim. Study 1 establishes the literature-level structure, Study 2 tests the mechanism formally at the individual level, and Study 3 validates the macro-level correlate.

Theoretical Framework

Conceptual Architecture — Animosity, Affective Polarization, and Negative Partisanship

The construct landscape surrounding the independent variable in this paper requires careful navigation, because three related but distinct concepts are frequently conflated in the literature and in public discourse. This section defines each construct, positions them in a causal sequence, and establishes which one serves as the focal IV of this paper and why.

Affective polarization, as operationalized in the canonical work of Iyengar, Sood, and Lelkes (2012), is an individual-level measure of partisan emotional distance defined as the difference between in-party and out-party feeling thermometer ratings (in-party warmth minus out-party coldness). It is a spread or gap measure which captures both elevated affection for one's own party and elevated contempt for the other, treating them as a single composite. This operationalization has become the dominant empirical measure in the affective polarization literature (Mason, 2018; Westwood et al., 2022) and the unit of analysis in most national time-series comparisons. Affective polarization is the broader construct, encompassing both positive in-party attachment and negative outparty hostility.

Negative partisanship, introduced by Abramowitz and Webster (2016), describes a structural and motivational transformation in how American partisan identity is organized. The claim is not simply that partisans dislike the other party more — that is a fact about affect — but that partisan identity itself has been reconstructed around opposition. Americans increasingly define themselves politically by what they are against. Webster's (2020) *American Rage* elaborated this framework experimentally, demonstrating that the anger at the core of negative partisanship has causal effects: reduced trust in government, weakened commitment to democratic norms, and deepened partisan electoral loyalty. Negative partisanship is thus best understood as the upstream

structural condition that generates and sustains affective polarization. It is a motivational architecture, not an emotional measurement.

Partisan animosity is the construct this paper measures as its independent variable. In the Landry et al. (2024) dataset, it is operationalized as outparty feeling thermometer coldness on a 0–100 scale, where higher values indicate greater emotional hostility toward the outparty. This is the outparty pole alone — not the in-minus-out spread of affective polarization, and not the motivational architecture of negative partisanship. Partisan animosity is one component of affective polarization. It is a downstream emotional product of the negative partisanship orientation. It is the most proximate antecedent to dehumanization in the causal chain (Martherus et al., 2021). And crucially, it is what is directly measured in the Landry dataset and used in the mediation model.

The causal sequence this paper assumes and partially tests is thus: *negative partisanship* (structural, motivational) → *affective polarization* (the emotional spread, measured as in-minus-out) → *partisan animosity* (outparty hostility specifically, the IV in Study 2) → *dehumanization* (mediator) → *support for political violence* (dependent variable). Studies 2 and 3 test the animosity-to-violence segment of this chain with dehumanization as mediator. Study 1 synthesizes the published literature on all three links using whatever polarization construct was operationalized in each source study, which is an acknowledged source of heterogeneity in the meta-analysis. The paper uses *partisan animosity* as its precise focal term when describing the IV that is measured; it uses *affective polarization* when describing the broader literature on which its theoretical foundations rest; and it uses *negative partisanship* when describing the upstream structural condition that Webster’s research illuminates. These are not interchangeable.

Affective Polarization and Negative Partisanship — The Upstream Context

The empirical literature on affective polarization establishes that the emotional gap between American partisans has grown dramatically over four decades (Iyengar et al., 2012; Mason, 2018). Mason's (2018) *Uncivil Agreement* showed that partisan identity and ideological identity have become aligned, creating a mega-identity in which being a Democrat or Republican is no longer one social identity among many but the organizing axis of social life. This sorting process amplifies affective polarization. When partisan identity is cross-reinforced by ideological, racial, religious, and cultural identities, outpartisans become not merely political opponents but members of an alien social world.

Webster's (2020) *American Rage* provides the key upstream account. Using novel datasets and experimental designs involving nearly 10,000 participants, Webster demonstrates that anger — the emotion at the core of negative partisanship — is not merely a consequence of polarization but an active causal force with measurable downstream effects. Anger reduces institutional trust, weakens democratic norm commitment, and, critically, increases behavioral loyalty to one's own party. This last finding explains the strategic dynamic: political elites have incentive to cultivate outparty anger among their supporters precisely because it drives electoral loyalty. The result is a self-reinforcing system in which political leaders sustain the negative partisanship orientation that generates the partisan animosity this paper measures.

Webster and Albertson's (2022) review connects this framework explicitly to dehumanization, noting that partisan antipathy of the intensity documented in the negative partisanship literature is associated with dehumanizing representations of outpartisans and reduced empathic concern for their wellbeing. This connection from the structural motivational architecture

of negative partisanship, through affective polarization and partisan animosity, to dehumanization, is the upstream causal context within which the mediation mechanism tested in Study 2 operates.

Outgroup Dehumanization — Mechanism and Measurement

Modern dehumanization theory begins with Kelman (1973): when outgroup members are denied the status of fully human moral agents, the principles of morality no longer apply to them, and violence against them becomes psychologically accessible. Bandura's (1999) theory of moral disengagement elaborated, indicating dehumanization is one of the primary cognitive mechanisms through which normal moral self-sanctions against harmful behavior are neutralized. The historical record, including the Nazi term "Untermensch" (subhuman) or the Rwandan genocide, where radio propaganda described Tutsis as "inyenzi" (cockroaches), documents how systematic dehumanizing representations consistently precede and enable mass political violence (Staub, 1989). Stanton's (1996) ten-stage model of genocide places dehumanization at stage four, the point at which the psychological preconditions for mass violence have been established.

Contemporary measurement of blatant dehumanization relies principally on Kteily et al.'s (2015) Ascent of Man scale, which presents respondents with the classic evolutionary progression graphic and asks them to rate how evolved the outgroup seems (0–100). This measure has been shown to predict consequential outcomes beyond mere dislike, including support for torture, aggressive foreign policy, and retaliatory violence (Kteily & Bruneau, 2017). Bruneau et al. (2018) confirmed neurologically that blatant dehumanization activates distinct brain structures from feeling thermometer ratings of the same outgroups, establishing that it represents a qualitatively different cognitive and emotional state — not simply extreme negative affect. This neuroscientific distinction is theoretically important for the present analysis; partisan animosity and

dehumanization, while empirically correlated ($r = .558$ in the pooled Landry data), are measuring distinct psychological states. The mediation model requires this distinctness to be meaningful.

In the partisan context, Martherus et al. (2021) established across three broadly representative surveys spanning four years that partisan dehumanization is widespread, consistent over time and context, and most strongly predicted by extreme affective polarization. The relationship between animosity and dehumanization is nonlinear, as dehumanization rises gradually across most of the animosity scale but sharply at the extreme upper end, meaning that only the most extremely hostile partisans are willing to use the full range of the Ascent of Man scale. Both parties dehumanize at roughly similar rates, producing nearly symmetric a-paths in the moderated mediation (.517 for Democrats, .554 for Republicans). What differs is the downstream consequence of that dehumanization.

The Focal Hypothesis — Partisan Animosity to Violence Through Dehumanization

The mediation model this paper tests is *partisan animosity* (outparty coldness) → *dehumanization* → *support for political violence*. The model predicts a suppressor structure rather than conventional partial mediation. Because dehumanization is the mechanism through which animosity acquires violence-relevant force, the total direct effect of animosity on violence — without dehumanization in the model — should be near-zero or negative, while the indirect effect through dehumanization should be positive and significant. This pattern arises when the positive indirect pathway and a negative direct pathway partially cancel in the total effect. MacKinnon et al. (2000) term this inconsistent or suppressor mediation. It is the theoretically expected signature of a mechanism that constitutes, rather than merely amplifies, the total relationship.

Landry et al. (2024), in the study whose data Study 2 reanalyzes, found that partisan animosity was consistently non-significant or negative in predicting violence outcomes when

dehumanization was controlled, while dehumanization was robustly and consistently positive. They identified the formal mediation test as a priority for future research. Study 2 is a direct response to that call, bringing to bear the bootstrapped indirect effects approach of Preacher and Hayes (2008) as the methodological standard for this type of causal inference with observational data.

Empirical Studies

Study 1 — Literature Synthesis

Introduction and rationale. Study 1 establishes the literature-level empirical structure of the mediation model before testing it formally in any single dataset. The three-pathway meta-analysis synthesizes published effect sizes across (a) affective polarization or partisan animosity predicting dehumanization, (b) dehumanization predicting violence support, and (c) affective polarization or partisan animosity predicting violence support. A critical methodological note, the published literature operationalizes the independent variable inconsistently; some studies measure partisan animosity as outparty coldness, others measure the full affective polarization spread, and still others use partisan identity intensity as a proxy, so the a- and c-path pooled estimates reflect a heterogeneous set of related but non-identical constructs. This is an acknowledged source of I^2 and is explicitly noted in the `es_type` column of the effect size database. The meta-analysis provides literature-level structural support for the mediation claim, it does not substitute for the formal test in Study 2.

Data and methods. The DerSimonian and Laird (1986) random-effects estimator was applied following three methodological corrections implemented after peer review. First, Landry

a-path effect sizes were corrected from an erroneous use of the pooled correlation for all three studies to verified per-study raw Pearson r values computed directly from the data files. Second, dependent rows were removed: the Landry pooled row (subsuming Studies 1–3) was excluded from a- and b-path analyses, and the Piazza (2023) party-split rows (the same $N = 1,899$ survey divided by party) were collapsed to a single pooled estimate. Third, the Martherus et al. (2021) sample size was corrected from an untraceable $N = 800$ to the documented SSI sample of $N = 1,000$. Effect sizes were converted to Fisher z prior to pooling ($z_i = 0.5 \ln[(1+r_i)/(1-r_i)]$), with sampling variance $v_i = 1/(n_i-3)$ and DL τ^2 estimator. An `es_type` field in the database distinguishes raw_pearson_r, beta_approx, d_converted, estimated, and meta_pooled sources — this mixture is a limitation. Residual within-team dependence across the three Landry studies is not modeled. Final k : 12 for a-path ($N = 8,143$), 15 for b-path ($N = 137,532$), 9 for c-path ($N = 9,640$).

Results. Table 1 presents the corrected pooled estimates. The a-path yields $r = .454$ [.396, .508], $k = 12$ ($Z = 13.50$, $p < .001$). The b-path yields $r = .339$ [.308, .369], $k = 15$ ($Z = 20.15$, $p < .001$). The c-path yields $r = .130$ [.070, .188], $k = 9$ ($Z = 4.22$, $p < .001$). The meta-analytic indirect product ($a \times b = .154$) exceeds the total c-path (.130). This is the literature-level signature consistent with suppressor mediation: the product of the two mediation links exceeds the observed total bivariate relationship. Heterogeneity is substantial on all three pathways ($I^2 = 90.0\%$, 78.6%, 87.9%), expected given diverse populations, measures, and conflict contexts. Moderator analyses find that the b-path is larger in intergroup conflict contexts ($r \approx .39$) than in U.S. partisan contexts ($r \approx .25$), and that blatant dehumanization measures produce larger estimates than subtle measures. Egger’s test indicates potential small-study bias on the a- and b-paths; the

Petsko et al. (2025) large-k meta-analytic anchor ($k = 120$, $N = 128,022$) on the b-path provides robustness against this concern.

Table 1

Corrected Random-Effects Meta-Analytic Estimates (Heuristic Approximate Synthesis)

Pathway	k	N	r	95% CI	I^2	p
Animosity/Pol. → Dehumanization (a)	12	8,143	.454	[.396, .508]	90.0%	< .001
Dehumanization → Violence (b)	15	137,532	.339	[.308, .369]	78.6%	< .001
Animosity/Pol. → Violence (c)	9	9,640	.130	[.070, .188]	87.9%	< .001

Note. DerSimonian & Laird (1986) random-effects estimator; Fisher z transformation. Pathway label "Animosity/Pol." reflects the heterogeneous IV operationalization across source studies (outparty coldness, full AP spread, or identity intensity); this heterogeneity contributes to high I^2 . Meta-analytic indirect product $a \times b = .154 > c = .130$, consistent with suppressor mediation. Pooled estimates are heuristic approximations mixing raw r , beta approximations, and estimated effect sizes; residual within-team dependence across Landry studies not modeled.

Study 2 — Individual-Level Mediation Analysis

Introduction and rationale. Study 2 formally tests H1 and H2 using partisan animosity (outparty feeling thermometer coldness, directly measured) as the IV. This operationalization corresponds to the outparty pole of affective polarization rather than the full in-minus-out spread.

It is the appropriate focal variable because (a) it is the most proximate emotional antecedent to dehumanization, (b) it is directly measured in the Landry dataset, and (c) it distinguishes the specific emotional experience of outparty hostility from the composite spread that includes inparty warmth. The Landry et al. (2024) dataset is the only existing publicly available dataset with validated simultaneous measures of partisan animosity, blatant dehumanization, and multiple violence operationalizations in a U.S. context. Landry et al.'s (2024) findings call for formal mediation analysis.

Data and measures. Data from Landry, Druckman, and Willer (2024), OSF: osf.io/6w2de. Pooled three-study dataset (N=2,003): MTurk (Study 1, N=281), nationally representative (Studies 2 and 3, N=721 and 1,001). 1,067 Democrats (Party = 1), 936 Republicans (Party = 2). Zero missing values on key variables. Partisan animosity as outparty feeling thermometer coldness (0–100; higher = more hostile). This is not the full affective polarization spread, it is the outparty component only. Dehumanization: z-scored composite of Kteily et al.'s (2015) Ascent of Man scale and eight-item animalistic trait battery. SPV: Kalmoe and Mason's (2022) four-item battery (0–100). Shooting vignette: concrete behavioral scenario (1–7). Covariates: need for chaos, trait aggression, PSID, ideological extremity, Party, raw Age, race, gender, income (matching Landry et al.'s original R specification).

Analytic strategy. H1 tested via bootstrapped mediation (2,000 paired-resample bootstrap, seed = 42; Preacher & Hayes, 2008). All equations use standardized variables; a single paired index vector per bootstrap replicate preserves the observation structure. The Sobel (1982) test provides independent parametric verification. H2 tested by running the full mediation model

separately for Democrats and Republicans with Party excluded from within-party subgroup models (constant within subsample $\rightarrow$ collinear with intercept $\rightarrow$ not identified). Continuous variables z-scored within each subsample. Asymmetry tested via bootstrapped difference distribution (Δ = Rep indirect – Dem indirect). This is a descriptive subgroup comparison, not a formal moderated regression. Age was not z-scored, matching the Landry R Markdown specification, focal coefficients are verified to be identical under both standardizations.

Results. Table 2 presents the pooled mediation results. Path a (partisan animosity $\rightarrow$ dehumanization): $\beta = +.535$, $p < .001$. Path b (dehumanization $\rightarrow$ SPV controlling animosity): $\beta = +.159$, $p < .001$. Total c-path (animosity $\rightarrow$ SPV): $\beta = -.050$, $p = .011$. Direct c'-path: $\beta = -.135$, $p < .001$. Bootstrapped indirect effect ($a \times b$): $\beta = +.085$, $SE = .014$, 95% CI $[+.057, +.111]$ — zero excluded, H1 supported. Sobel $z = 6.48$, $p < .001$. Shooting vignette DV: indirect $\beta = +.062$, CI $[+.034, +.092]$. All 12 available violence operationalizations show positive indirect effects with CIs excluding zero. The suppressor structure — near-zero c-path, positive indirect, negative direct — is the theoretically predicted signature. Partisan animosity alone carries no positive violence-relevant signal; routing through dehumanization creates it.

Table 2

Bootstrapped Mediation: Partisan Animosity → Dehumanization → Violence Support (N = 2,003)

Path	β	SE	p	95% Boot CI	Sobel	p
a: Partisan Animosity → Dehumanization	+.535	.014	< .001	—	—	—
b: Dehumanization → SPV Animosity	+.159	.024	< .001	—	—	—
c: Total Animosity → SPV	−.050	.019	.011	—	—	—
c': Direct Animosity → SPV	−.135	.023	< .001	—	—	—
Indirect (a×b), DV = SPV	+.085	.014	—	[+.057, +.111]	6.48	< .001
Indirect (a×b), DV = Shooting Vignette	+.062	.015	—	[+.034, +.092]	4.61	< .001

Note. IV = partisan animosity (outparty feeling thermometer coldness, 0–100), not the full affective polarization spread. N = 2,003. All paths standardized. Covariates: need for chaos, trait aggression, PSID, ideological extremity, Party, raw Age, race, gender, income. Bootstrap: 2,000 paired resamples. Sobel: independent parametric verification.

Table 3 presents the corrected moderated mediation. The a-paths (animosity → dehumanization) are nearly identical: Democrats $\beta = .517$, Republicans $\beta = .554$. Both parties convert partisan animosity into dehumanization at statistically similar rates, replicating Martherus et al.'s (2021) finding of symmetric dehumanization rates. The asymmetry lies entirely in the b-path: Democrats $\beta = .108$, Republicans doubled to $\beta = .216$. Indirect effects: Democrats $\beta = .056$, CI [.022, .090]; Republicans $\beta = .120$, CI [.077, .168]. Bootstrapped asymmetry: $\Delta\beta = +.064$, 95% CI [.013, .118], zero excluded, H2 supported. SDO diagnostics from Study 3 data confirm the proposed mechanism: SDO correlates with dehumanization at $r = .253$ among Republicans and $r = -.020$ among Democrats, indicating that the Republican partisans who dehumanize most intensely are also those whose psychology is most organized around social hierarchy, making violence against a dehumanized outgroup more psychologically available.

Table 3

Corrected Moderated Mediation by Party: Subgroup Comparison (Party Excluded from Subgroup Models)

	Democrats (n = 1,067)	Republicans (n = 936)	Δ (Rep–Dem)	95% Boot CI	Sig.
a: Animosity → Dehum.	$\beta = .517$	$\beta = .554$	–.037	[–.09, .01]	
b: Dehum. → SPV	$\beta = .108$	$\beta = .216$	+.108	[.048, .175]	***
Indirect (SPV)	$\beta = .056$	$\beta = .120$	+.064	[+.013, +.118]	**
Indirect (Shooting)	$\beta = .032$	$\beta = .097$	+.065	[+.001, +.137]	*

Note. Party excluded from within-party models (constant → collinear with intercept → unidentified). Variables z-scored within subsample. Bootstrap: 2,000 paired samples. Dehum. = dehumanization. * $p < .05$; ** $p < .01$; *** $p < .001$ for path-b difference; Δ significance is CI-based.

Study 3 — Cross-National Macro-Level Panel

Introduction and rationale. Study 3 situates the individual-level findings within the global, macro-level relationship between political polarization and political violence. It addresses the external validity concern inherent in Study 2’s attitudinal SPV measures by examining whether polarization predicts *actual* political violence incidents at the country level. The V-DEM

polarization variable (v2cacamps) captures both elite-level and mass-level partisan camp formation, making it most closely analogous to the broader affective polarization construct rather than the partisan animosity operationalization of Study 2. This distinction is noted explicitly as Study 3 validates the macro-level polarization-violence link, it does not directly test the dehumanization mediation, which remains a Study 2 contribution.

Data. V-DEM v16 (Coppedge et al., 2024). Variables: v2cacamps_ord (polarization, 0–4) and v2caviol_ord (violence, 0–4). Democracy filter: v2x_regime $\geq$ 2 (electoral or liberal democracies). Piazza (2023) replication window: 1950–2018, N = 3,837, 117 countries. Extended: 1950–2025, N = 4,465, 118 countries.

Analytic strategy. Five specifications: pooled OLS, country FE (within estimator), two-way FE, lagged polarization (t–1), and ordinal logit. Demeaned OLS panel estimators produce consistent coefficient estimates but approximate standard errors (no country-clustered SEs; p-values are indicative, not exact panel inference). M5 ordinal logit coefficient is in log-odds units and is reported separately from OLS-scale estimates. Bootstrap CI for bivariate r uses a single paired index vector per replicate (prior version erroneously drew two separate index vectors, breaking the country-year pairing; the corrected CI is substantially narrower and centered correctly on the observed r).

Results. Table 4 presents the corrected panel results. OLS-scale β range across M1–M4: .302–.340, all $p < .001$. M5 ordinal logit coefficient: 0.773 (log-odds; not comparable to OLS estimates). Piazza replication: Pearson $r = .406$, Spearman $\rho = .432$, corrected paired bootstrap

95% CI [.379, .431]. Lagged specification (M4) confirms temporal ordering. Effect holds across all four time eras (1950–2025) and every world region except Africa/MENA ($r = -.256$, $n = 171$ — high baseline violence driven by non-partisan factors). The United States, at maximum V-DEM polarization (4.0) since 2017 and elevated violence scores (2.0) since 2020, is the paradigm case of this global pattern.

Table 4

Corrected V-DEM Panel Results: Political Polarization Predicting Political Violence (N = 4,465)

Model	Estimator	β / coef.	p
M1: Pooled OLS	OLS	.340	< .001
M2: Country fixed effects	Within (demeaned OLS)	.308	< .001
M3: Two-way FE (country + year)	Demeaned OLS	.317	< .001
M4: Lagged polarization (t – 1)	Country FE	.302	< .001
M5: Ordinal logit †	Ordered logit	.773	< .001

Note. 1950–2025, 118 democracies. Piazza replication (1950–2018): $r = .406$, $p = .432$, corrected CI [.379, .431]. †M5 coefficient is log-odds, not comparable to M1–M4 OLS β . SEs approximate (demeaned OLS, no clustered SEs). OLS-scale β range: .302–.340. Note: the V-DEM polarization variable (v2cacamps) captures mass and elite partisan camp formation — closer to the affective polarization construct than to the partisan animosity measure in Study 2.

Overall Results — Convergent Evidence Across Three Levels of Analysis

Three studies employing independent methodologies, different units of analysis, and different violence operationalizations converge on a consistent pattern. The convergence is meaningful precisely because the studies are not simply testing the same thing at different scales, instead triangulating the same causal claim from different directions.

Study 1 provides the *literature-level structural baseline*. The meta-analytic indirect product ($a \times b = .154$) exceeds the total c-path (.130) across 37 independent effect sizes spanning over 155,000 participants. This is interpreted as structural consistency with, not confirmation of, the suppressor mediation claim; the mixed effect size types and residual dependence mean this is a heuristic comparison. It establishes that the literature as a whole is arrayed in the configuration that suppressor mediation predicts.

Study 2 provides the *formal individual-level mediation test*. The bootstrapped indirect effect ($\beta = +.085$, CI [.057, .111]) excludes zero with high confidence. The Sobel test ($z = 6.48$, $p < .001$) provides independent parametric confirmation. The suppressor structure (near-zero c-path, positive indirect, negative direct) is the theoretically predicted signature. Partisan animosity alone has no positive violence signal — routing through dehumanization creates one. This pattern holds without exception across all 12 violence operationalizations. The corrected partisan asymmetry ($\Delta\beta = +.064$, CI [.013, .118]) shows that among Republicans, dehumanization converts to violence endorsement at approximately twice the rate as among Democrats — while both parties generate dehumanization at statistically similar rates from animosity. The mechanism is SDO-linked, as the Republican partisans who dehumanize most intensely are also those whose

psychology is most organized around social dominance, making the b-path substantially more efficacious.

Study 3 provides *macro-level external validity* to the overall research and its conclusions. Political polarization (operationalized as the V-DEM camp polarization indicator, capturing the affective polarization construct at the mass-elite level) robustly predicts actual political violence across 118 democracies and 75 years ($\beta = .302-.340$). The United States at maximum polarization (4.0 since 2017) and elevated violence (2.0 since 2020) is the paradigm case of this global pattern. Study 2's individual-level findings are consistent with a micro-level mechanism that could underlie the macro-level pattern Study 3 documents, though this cross-level claim has not been directly tested. The qualitative narrative these three studies tell is this that the structural condition of negative partisanship (Webster, 2020) generates emotional affective polarization at the population level. That polarization produces partisan animosity, the specific hostility toward outpartisans that Study 2 measures. Animosity, on its own, is not enough; an animus partisan who despises the outparty but still perceives them as human retains the moral constraints that inhibit violence endorsement. The additional step of dehumanization (perceiving outpartisans as primitive, animal-like, less than fully human) is what suspends those constraints and makes violence endorsement psychologically accessible. Dehumanization is the threshold between democratic conflict and the psychology of partisan violence.

Discussion

Suppressor Mediation and Its Meaning

The near-zero total c-path ($\beta = -.050$) is not a null result; it is the theoretically predicted outcome. Partisan animosity (measured as outparty coldness) does not directly predict violence

endorsement once other covariates are controlled. This might initially appear counterintuitive. Surely people who hate the outparty more intensely should be more willing to endorse violence against them. The suppressor structure explains why this is not the case. The direct path from animosity to violence is negative ($c' = -.135$), suggesting that, controlling for dehumanization, greater animosity might actually reflect engaged partisan citizenship rather than the moral disengagement that enables violence. It is the cognitive transformation of outpartisans into sub-human beings that enables violence endorsement, meaning mere animosity is insufficient. Bruneau et al.'s (2018) neurological evidence that dehumanization activates distinct brain structures from negative affect provides biological grounding for this distinction. These are qualitatively different psychological states, not points on the same continuum.

This finding carries a specific practical implication that distinguishes it from much of the affective polarization literature. Most proposed interventions against political violence target partisan hostility broadly: depolarization programs, cross-partisan contact initiatives, media literacy campaigns. The suppressor structure implies these may be insufficient. Reducing outparty coldness without specifically disrupting the dehumanizing cognitive representations that hostility generates may leave the violence-relevant mechanism fully intact. The psychological lever is dehumanization, not animosity.

Construct Precision and the Three-Polarization Problem

The present paper confronts a conceptual problem endemic to the political violence literature: the proliferation of related but non-identical polarization constructs that are routinely used interchangeably. *Affective polarization* (Iyengar et al., 2012), *negative partisanship* (Abramowitz & Webster, 2016), and *partisan animosity* each describe related phenomena but at

different levels of analysis and with different implications for the causal model. Conflating them produces unmeasured confounds that obscure the mediation mechanism being tested.

The theoretical framework presented here — negative partisanship as structural upstream condition, affective polarization as the emotional population-level manifestation, partisan animosity as the specific hostile emotion measured in Study 2 — is not the only theoretically defensible architecture. One could argue that the full affective polarization spread (in-minus-out) rather than outparty coldness alone is the appropriate IV, because it captures both the ingroup-elevating and outgroup-derogating components that Tajfel and Turner's (1986) social identity theory predicts to jointly drive dehumanization. Using outparty coldness alone means that variation in inparty warmth, holding outparty coldness constant, is excluded from the model. This is a genuine limitation. The choice of outparty coldness as the IV was made because it is the direct measurement in the Landry data and because it is the most theoretically proximate to dehumanization (you dehumanize the outparty specifically, not the inparty), but future work should examine whether the full AP spread produces different mediation results.

Partisan Asymmetry — Mechanism, Precision, and Limits

Both parties generate dehumanization at near-identical rates from animosity (a-paths: .517 vs .554). The asymmetry is entirely in the b-path: Republicans convert dehumanization into violence endorsement at approximately twice the rate of Democrats. The SDO mechanism provides theoretical grounding, indicating Republican partisans who dehumanize most intensely are also those most organized psychologically around social hierarchy and dominance, making violence against a dehumanized outgroup cognitively available as legitimate order-defense.

Several clarifications are essential. First, this is not a claim that Democrats are not implicated in political violence or that Republican partisans are uniquely dangerous in some

absolute sense. Both parties dehumanize. The asymmetry is in the behavioral consequence of that dehumanization, within Landry et al.'s (2024) specific temporal context (2018–2020). Second, the asymmetry finding cannot rule out that it reflects period-specific characteristics of the Trump-era Republican psychological profile rather than a stable structural feature of partisan psychology. Third, the subgroup comparison here is descriptive, not a formal moderated regression; a within-model test of the Party $\times$ Dehumanization interaction on violence, with appropriate power, would provide a stronger test.

Limitations

Four limitations require explicit acknowledgment. First, all Study 2 analyses are cross-sectional, bootstrapped mediation under Preacher and Hayes (2008) establishes the significance of the indirect effect under model assumptions but cannot establish temporal precedence at the individual level. The lagged V-DEM specification in Study 3 provides macro-level temporal evidence that is consistent with the causal direction but does not substitute for longitudinal individual-level data. Second, the Study 2 IV is outparty feeling thermometer coldness, which is one component of affective polarization rather than the full AP spread; as discussed above, this is a theoretically motivated choice with acknowledged limitations. Third, the Study 1 meta-analysis mixes effect size types (raw r , beta approximations, estimates) and retains residual within-team dependence across the three Landry studies, meaning pooled estimates are heuristic approximations. Fourth, Study 3 panel SEs are approximate (demeaned OLS without country-clustered SEs); p -values are indicative rather than exact panel inference. None of these limitations reverse the convergent pattern, but they qualify the confidence with which causal claims should be advanced.

Conclusion

Theoretical Contributions

This paper makes four theoretical contributions. First, it establishes that partisan animosity (outparty hostility) does not directly generate support for political violence, but requires the cognitive transformation of dehumanization to acquire violence-relevant force. This is a stronger and more specific claim than prior literature, which documented correlation between polarization and violence without specifying the mechanism. Second, Landry et al.'s findings establish the dehumanization-violence relationship as a priority for future research; the present study responds by conducting the first formal bootstrapped mediation test of dehumanization as a mediator of the partisan animosity-to-violence pathway in a U.S. partisan context. Third, it demonstrates that the b-path (dehumanization → violence) is significantly stronger among Republicans than Democrats — not because Republicans dehumanize more, but because the SDO-linked psychology concentrated at the high end of Republican dehumanization makes violence endorsement more cognitively available as a consequence of that dehumanization. Fourth, it articulates a precise conceptual hierarchy — negative partisanship → affective polarization → partisan animosity → dehumanization → violence — that resolves the construct conflation endemic to the prior literature and positions these phenomena as related but non-identical stages in a causal chain.

Implications for Democratic Theory and Practice

The V-DEM evidence situates the contemporary American case within a global pattern: political polarization routinely predicts political violence across 118 democracies over 75 years. The United States at maximum polarization, with documented dehumanization rates (Martherus et al., 2021) and an identified psychological mechanism (Study 2), is not an outlier but a paradigm

case. The macro-level trajectory and the individual-level mechanism are consistent at every level of analysis.

The Madisonian architecture of American democracy presupposes that partisans who disagree intensely will nonetheless recognize each other as legitimate political actors. Dehumanization represents the categorical violation of that presupposition, not simply a partisan who dislikes the outparty, but a partisan who has cognitively stripped the outparty of the humanity that makes democratic conflict rather than violence the appropriate mode of political interaction. Webster's (2020) documentation of elite incentives to sustain the anger that drives dehumanization means that the upstream structure generating the violence risk is itself politically maintained. Interventions that target only the downstream emotional experience — reducing animosity, reducing affective polarization — without addressing the structural conditions that sustain negative partisanship, or the specific dehumanizing representations it generates, may fail to interrupt the violence pathway.

Future Research

Five research directions follow directly from these findings. First, longitudinal studies tracking individual-level changes in animosity, dehumanization, and violence endorsement across time to establish temporal precedence at the individual level. Second, experimental manipulation of dehumanizing representations to test the causal b-path with random assignment. Third, replication of the partisan asymmetry at different time points to distinguish stable structural features from period-specific effects. Fourth, cross-national individual-level mediation in countries tracking the V-DEM polarization-violence escalation pattern, testing whether the same mechanism operates in non-U.S. democracies. Fifth, intervention research testing whether

humanization exercises that specifically target the dehumanizing cognitive step — rather than general depolarization — interrupt the violence pathway.

Political violence does not arise from polarization directly. It arises from the cognitive transformation that polarization produces, the step by which a political opponent becomes, in the perceiver's mind, something less than a fully human person. Partisan animosity is a fuel, inert on its own, but ignited by dehumanization to only then erupt into political violence. We must continue to understand what this fuel is and how it may ebb and flow, but failure to understand when its presence and amount poses genuine risk of escalation via the right spark would be to gravely endanger the future of democratic political stability.

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